BHARATVERSE

VAYU

CHAPTER 1
WRONG SEA

Arjun had been awake for thirty-one hours when he reached the Bay of Bengal.

After Bhiwandi he had gone home, eaten nothing, sat on the floor of his flat with his back against the wall, and tried to understand the four seconds.

He knew what had happened in the godown. He had broken. A man in a burning building had said her name and he had come apart.

Zara!

What he could not explain was how he had climbed back out by his own collar, when something had held the quiet for him just long enough.

It had not felt like his own control. It had felt like a hand on the back of his neck, and a number he almost recognised.

Dr. Rao's maps put the second point under the Bay of Bengal, thirty metres down, beneath an old fort off the Chennai coast.

CHENNAI

30 m

If the force there had woken, someone was carrying it. The Division wanted them. So did whoever had taken his sister. He wanted to reach them first.

He flew a hundred metres above the water at half speed with the pressure bubble up.

Dawn was a grey smear to the east, and a depression was forming out in the Bay, bringing the north-east monsoon's first real rain.

MAHABALIPURAM

He crossed the coast at Mahabalipuram and felt, as he left the land, a change.

He months his pressure sense had treated the ocean as enormous and indifferent, a flat vast mass.

This sea was not indifferent.

Every wave under him leaned a degree toward his shadow. Swells rose where he passed and fell behind him.

Each raindrop that touched his skin, he realised, was reporting.

It was not hostile and it was not welcoming. It was the attention of a very large animal that has noticed something moving at the edge of its territory.

He had been watched before, by a woman at a conference in Pune.

This was different. This was being read.

The coordinates were four kilometres ahead. He slowed.

He thought:

she's here.

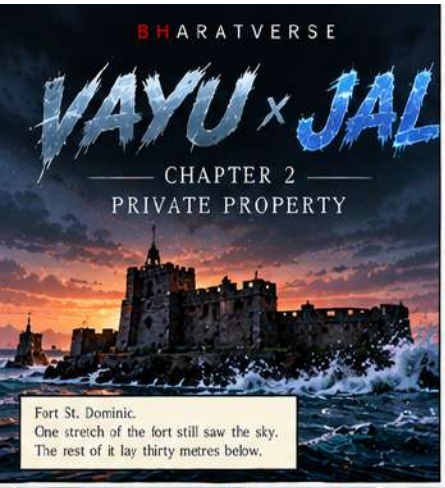
And, a heartbeat later:

she knows I'm here.

BHARATVERSE

VAYU x JAL

CHAPTER 2
PRIVATE PROPERTY

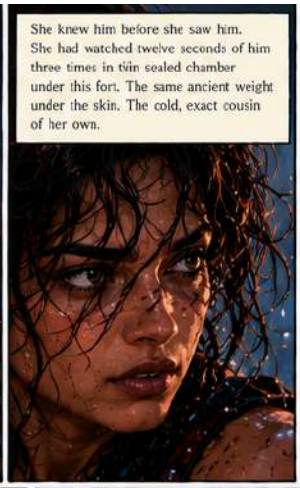


Fort St. Dominic.
One stretch of the fort still saw the sky.
The rest of it lay thirty metres below.



Zara had felt him since the coast.
Rain falls on everything, and every drop that touched the man crossing the Bay was a drop she could feel.

A weight.
A heartbeat.
A body moving through the air with precision.



She knew him before she saw him.
She had watched twelve seconds of him three times in tvin sealed chamber under this fort. The same ancient weight under the skin. The cold, exact cousin of her own.



Two acquisition teams, four and then six: black wetsuits, expensive instruments, no mercy, and always at night, always in numbers. This one came at dawn, alone, straight at her fort with the light behind him.

Either very stupid or very sure.



"Rajan," she said, without turning.

Go home.

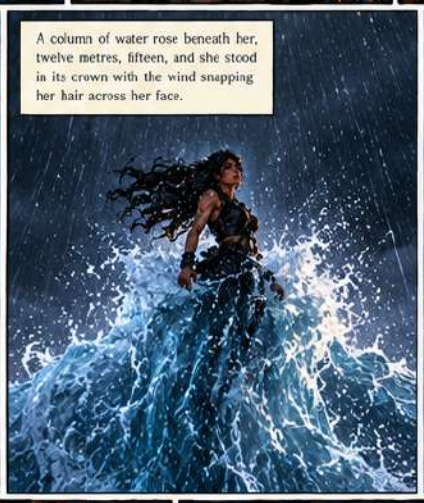
Boss—

Take the boat. Tell nobody.

When his engine had faded, she stood, said "Alright. Fine" to the ocean, and stepped off the wall.



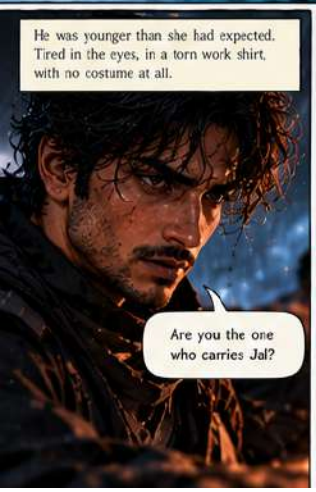
The Bay took her up.



A column of water rose beneath her, twelve metres, fifteen, and she stood in its crown with the wind snapping her hair across her face.



"Private property," said Zara.



He was younger than she had expected. Tired in the eyes, in a torn work shirt, with no costume at all.

Are you the one who carries Jal?



I don't know that word.



Dr. Kiran Rao calls it **Jal-shakti.** Water.
There are five forces, and—



Who is Dr. Kiran Rao?

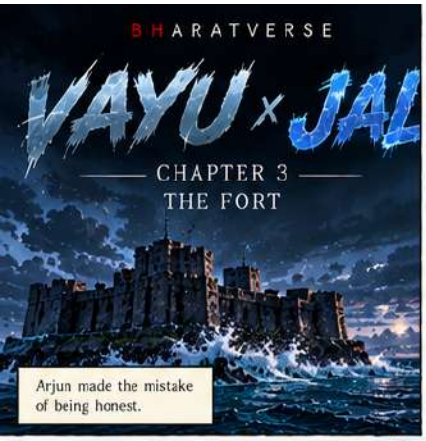


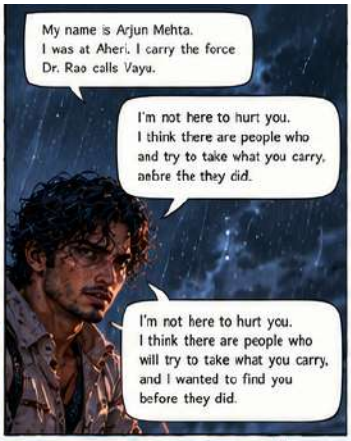
She ran the experiment at Aheri. It's what did this to me.

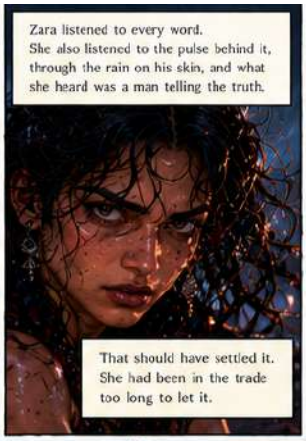


That's three words in a row I don't like," said Zara.

Aheri. Experiment. Me.


BHARATVERSE
VAYU x JAL
CHAPTER 3
THE FORT
Arjun made the mistake of being honest.


My name is Arjun Mehta. I was at Aheri. I carry the force Dr. Rao calls Vayu.
I'm not here to hurt you. I think there are people who and try to take what you carry, anbre the they did.
I'm not here to hurt you. I think there are people who will try to take what you carry, and I wanted to find you before they did.


Zara listened to every word. She also listened to the pulse behind it, through the rain on his skin, and what she heard was a man telling the truth.
That should have settled it. She had been in the trade too long to let it.


The last man who told me he wsan't here to hurt me," had a rifle.
I don't have a rifle.
You have the sky. It's worse.


I'm looking for the people who took my sister.
They took her out of Aheri before the dust settled. I think they're after the points. All five. All of you.


For a second Zara almost believed him.
Then she saw his eyes slide past her, through the rain, to the black rampart behind her.
It was exactly how the leader of the first team had looked at it, one night in the dark, before he said stand aside.


That's where it is, Arjun said quietly.
Under there. Isn't it?


Don't look at it.


I only want to see the structure. I'm an engineer. I just want to—


He drifted a metre toward the fort.


"That," said Zara, "was a mistake.
She did not decide to do it. Her whole life, every instinct for what she owned had been trained on exactly this: a stranger leaning toward the one thing in the world she was not going to share.
The Bay answered before she had finished the thought.


Water rose.
Not a wave. A wall.


WHOOOOSH


The force hit him mid-air, wrapping around him in a spiral of water and weight.
It drove him back, spinning, toward the sea.
SPLASHHH


Cold. Heavy. Absolute.
This was not like wind. This was another kind of strength.



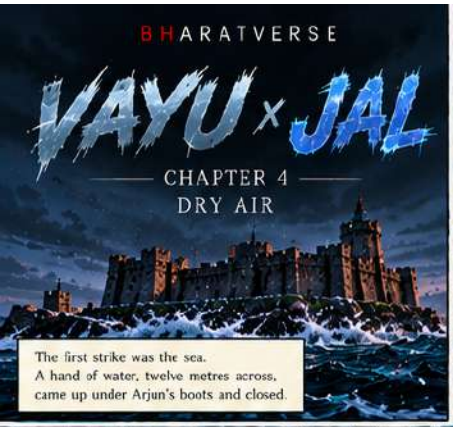

He surfaced, coughing, a hundred metres away.
Not hurt. But very clear about one thing.
She was not going to let him near that fort. Not yet.


Zara watched him, silent.
The fort remained behind her. Thirty metres below. Still hers.

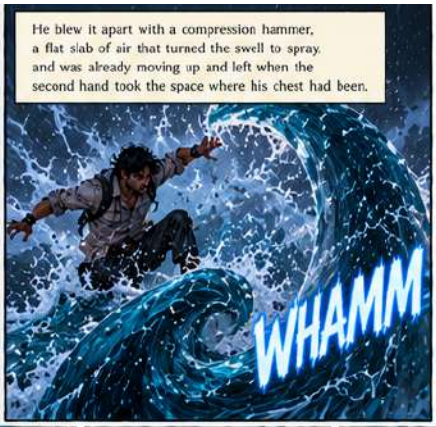
BHARATVERSE

VAYU x JAL

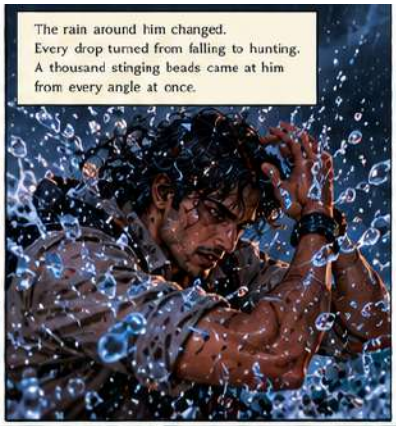
CHAPTER 4
DRY AIR



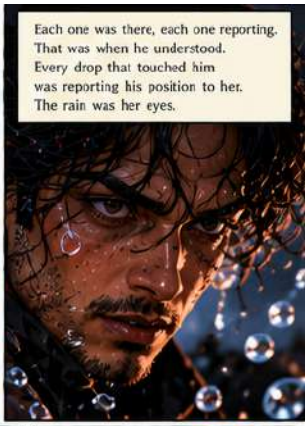
The first strike was the sea.
A hand of water, twelve metres across,
came up under Arjun's boots and closed.



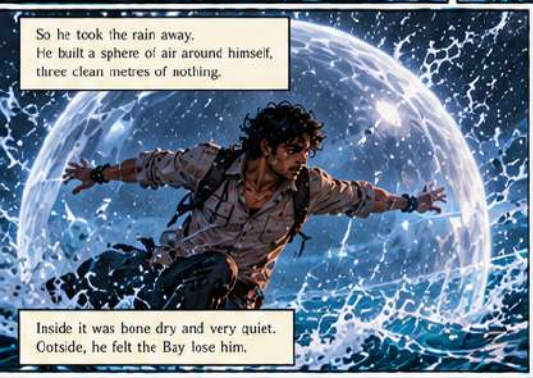
He blew it apart with a compression hammer,
a flat slab of air that turned the swell to spray,
and was already moving up and left when the
second hand took the space where his chest had been.



The rain around him changed.
Every drop turned from falling to hunting.
A thousand stinging beads came at him
from every angle at once.

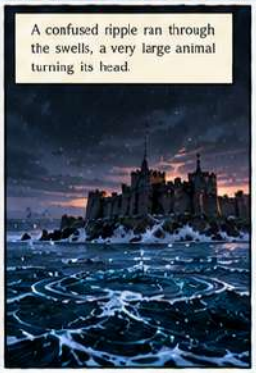


Each one was there, each one reporting.
That was when he understood.
Every drop that touched him
was reporting his position to her.
The rain was her eyes.



So he took the rain away.
He built a sphere of air around himself,
three clean metres of nothing.

Inside it was bone dry and very quiet.
Outside, he felt the Bay lose him.



A confused ripple ran through
the swells, a very large animal
turning its head.



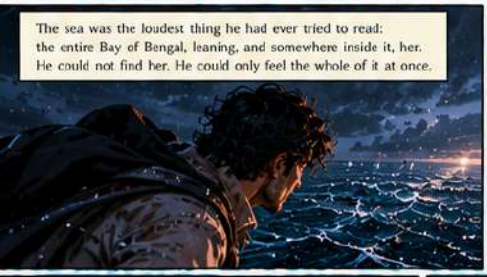
"Clever," he heard her say,
or felt her say, through the rain.



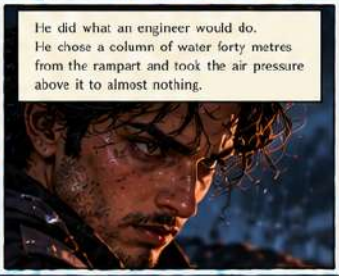
He moved fast now, inside the
dry bubble, to where her column
had stood.



She was not there.
She had gone into the sea,
a woman dissolving into the swell
like salt.



The sea was the loudest thing he had ever tried to read:
the entire Bay of Bengal, leaning, and somewhere inside it, her.
He could not find her. He could only feel the whole of it at once.



He did what an engineer would do.
He chose a column of water forty metres
from the rampart and took the air pressure
above it to almost nothing.

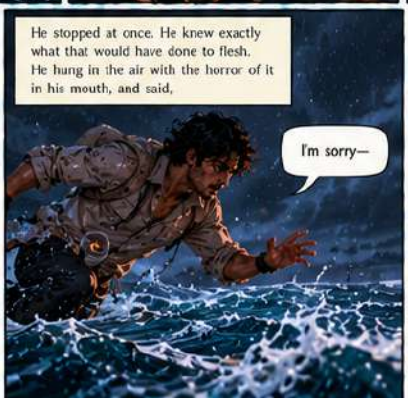


Water at low pressure boils without being heated.
The column bloomed white.

Bubbles formed and collapsed
in a roar like a hundred thousand
firecrackers, and out of it came
a sound that was not quite a scream:
the sound of something being pulled
apart at the seams.



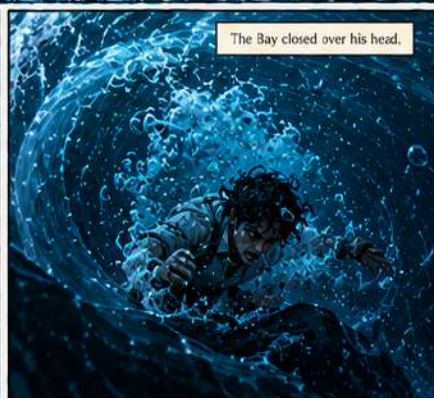
A woman fell out of the foam onto a swell,
gasping, her outline blurred, her hands shaking.



He stopped at once. He knew exactly
what that would have done to flesh.
He hung in the air with the horror of it
in his mouth, and said,

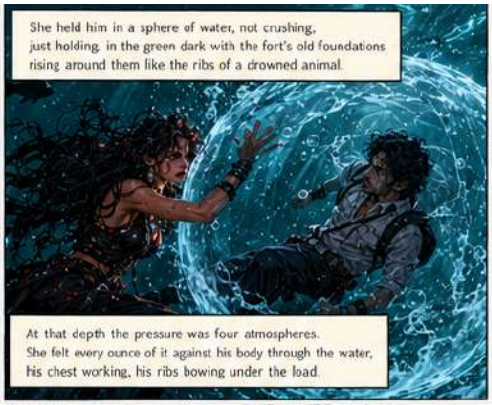


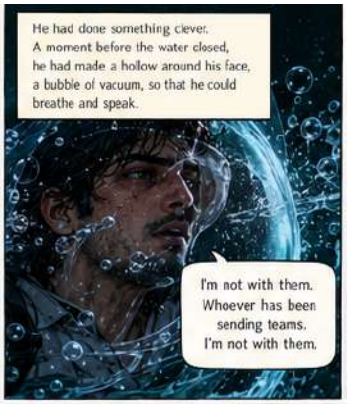
It was the wrong moment
to be sorry.



The Bay closed over his head.


BHARATVERSE
VAYU x JAL
CHAPTER 5
THIRTY METRES
She had him at thirty metres before she had finished being angry.


She held him in a sphere of water, not crushing, just holding. In the green dark with the fort's old foundations rising around them like the ribs of a drowned animal.
At that depth the pressure was four atmospheres. She felt every ounce of it against his body through the water, his chest working, his ribs bowing under the load.


He had done something clever. A moment before the water closed, he had made a hollow around his face, a bubble of vacuum, so that he could breathe and speak.
I'm not with them. Whoever has been sending teams. I'm not with them.


She felt his pulse through the water. Eighty-eight beats. Terrified, steady, holding. She had spent her life reading liars. His did not. It was not the heartbeat of a man hiding something.

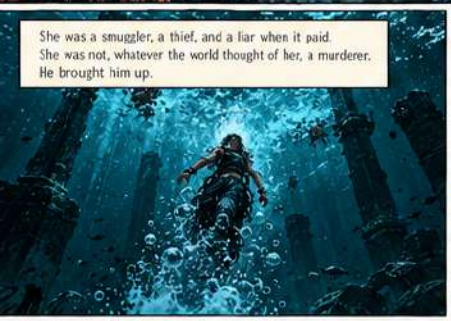

Who took your sister?
I don't know their name. I know they funded the experiment that did this to me. I know they took her out of a hot room within minutes. And I know they'll come for you.

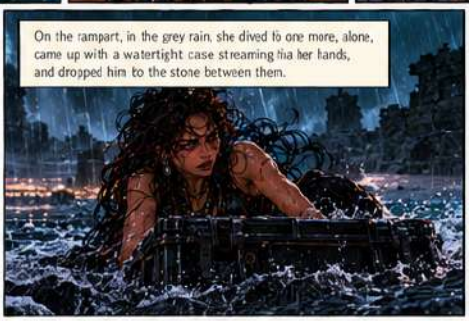

They've come twice.


Twice?


Four of them, then six. Black wetsuits, expensive cases, a man in charge who spoke a language I couldn't place.
They're all alive. I put them on a beach.

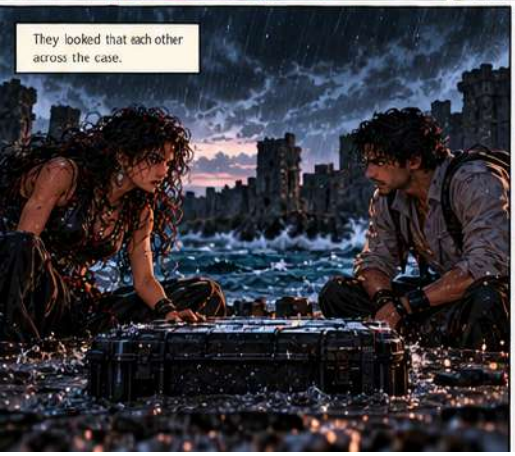

The beat of his chest changed. Not fear. Something close to relief.


She was a smuggler, a thief, and a liar when it paid. She was not, whatever the world thought of her, a murderer. He brought him up.


On the rampart, in the grey rain, she dived to one more, alone, came up with a watertight case streaming tha her hands, and dropped him to the stone between them.

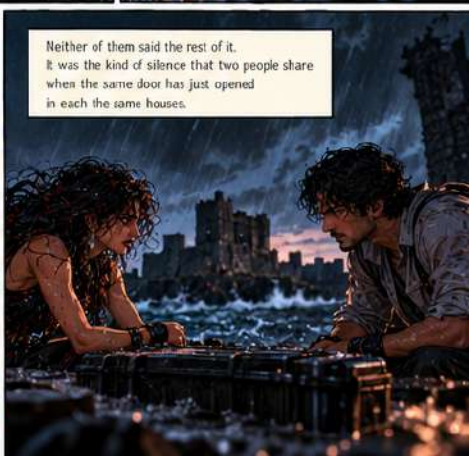

Stencilled tha the lid in clean white paint was a small circle crossed ol a single line.

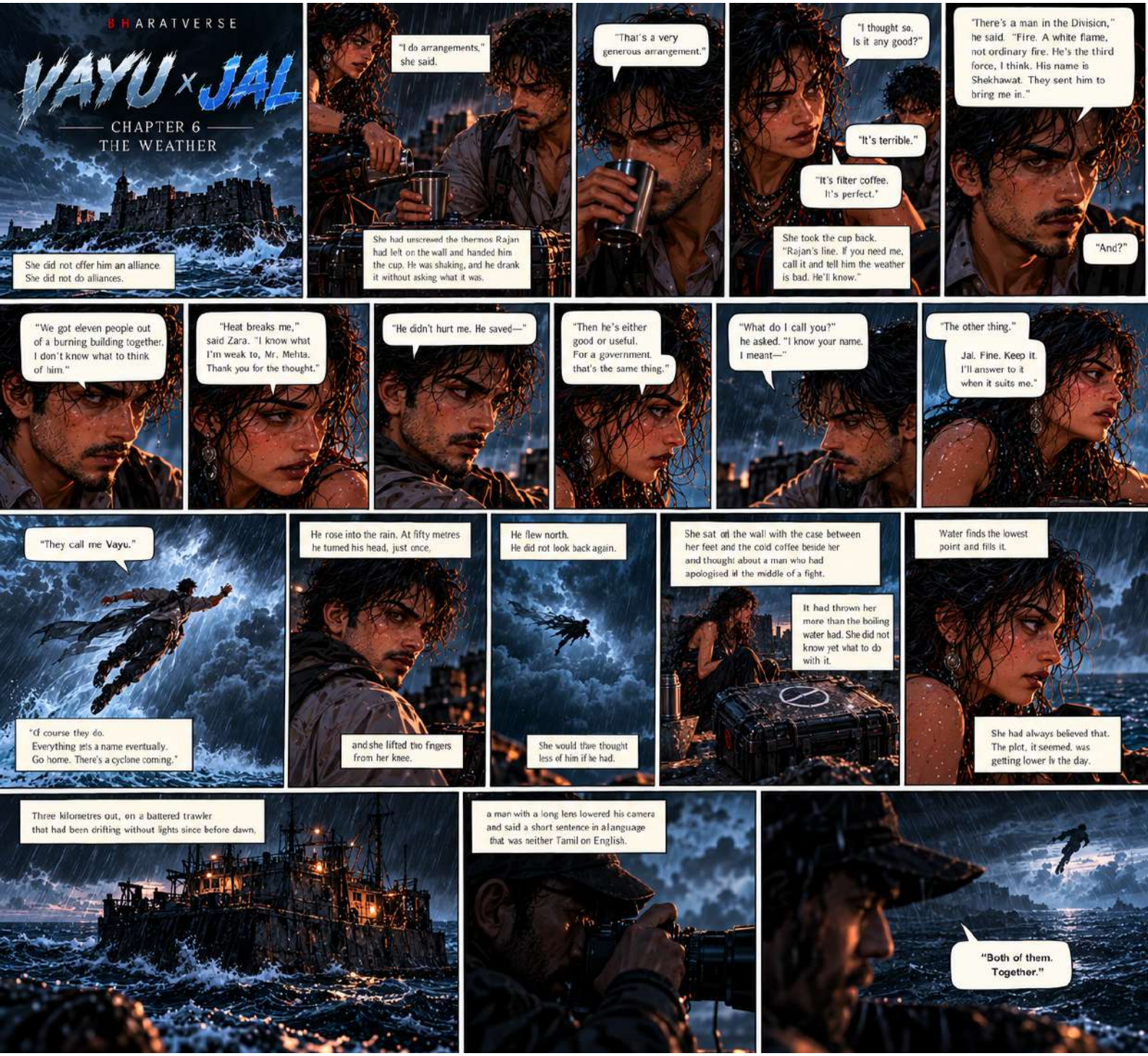

I've seen that. On Dr. Rao's grant letters. She never thought twice al a boiling Twenty years of funding, and that mark in the corner of every page.


They looked that each other across the case.


So the people who paid for your experiment...
...sent men to my fort.


And the people who took my sister.


Neither of them said the rest of it. It was the kind of silence that two people share when the same door has just opened in each the same houses.


BHARATVERSE
VAYU x JAL
CHAPTER 6
THE WEATHER
She did not offer him an alliance. She did not do alliances.
"I do arrangements," she said.
She had unscrewed the thermos Rajan had left on the wall and handed him the cup. He was shaking, and he drank it without asking what it was.
"That's a very generous arrangement."
"I thought so. Is it any good?"
"It's terrible."
"It's filter coffee. It's perfect."
She took the cup back. "Rajan's line. If you need me, call it and tell him the weather is bad. He'll know."
"There's a man in the Division," he said. "Fire. A white flame, not ordinary fire. He's the third force, I think. His name is Shekhawat. They sent him to bring me in."
"And?"
"We got eleven people out of a burning building together. I don't know what to think of him."
"Heat breaks me," said Zara. "I know what I'm weak to, Mr. Mehta. Thank you for the thought."
"He didn't hurt me. He saved—"
"Then he's either good or useful. For a government, that's the same thing."
"What do I call you?" he asked. "I know your name. I meant—"
"The other thing."
Jal. Fine. Keep it. I'll answer to it when it suits me."
"They call me Vayu."
"Of course they do. Everything gets a name eventually. Go home. There's a cyclone coming."
He rose into the rain. At fifty metres he turned his head, just once,
and she lifted two fingers from her knee.
He flew north. He did not look back again.
She would have thought less of him if he had.
She sat on the wall with the case between her feet and the cold coffee beside her and thought about a man who had apologised in the middle of a fight.
It had thrown her more than the boiling water had. She did not know yet what to do with it.
Water finds the lowest point and fills it.
She had always believed that. The plot, it seemed, was getting lower by the day.
Three kilometres out, on a battered trawler that had been drifting without lights since before dawn,
a man with a long lens lowered his camera and said a short sentence in a language that was neither Tamil on English.
"Both of them. Together."